Lesson 1.2: Picking the right feature

Claude Certified Associate – Foundations (CCAO-F) · Module 1: Platform & Model Foundations · Lesson 2 · 11:58

Description

Chat, web search, Research, artifacts, Projects and Cowork each do a different job, and the wrong pick shows: an answer you can't source, a long wait for a one-line fact, or the same files uploaded every week. This lesson builds one decision guide out of Anthropic's own guidance: four questions, asked in order, that route any task to the right feature. You then see where each piece comes from: the official exam guide, Anthropic's beginner course and the Help Center. Next, one real need for this course goes through three features in Claude Desktop with Sonnet 5.5. The question is what has changed in Claude's features since the July 2026 exam guide. It goes to plain chat first, then to Research, which comes back with a cited report. One of that report's claims is checked against Anthropic's release notes on screen. Finally, the findings become a one-page artifact, "Which feature for which job", with every row checked and two slips corrected. The lesson ends with one exam-style scenario, reasoned out loud.

Learning outcomes

By the end of this lesson you can:

1. Explain what each feature is for, and where it falls short.
2. Route any task with four questions.
3. Pick and combine features on a real job, then check the result.

Chapters

Time	Chapter
00:00	Preview and outcomes
00:34	Why it matters
01:04	The decision guide
02:32	Straight from the source
03:47	Hands-on: one need, three features
10:39	Exam angle
11:25	Recap and quick check

The decision guide: four questions, in order

This guide, its order and its cost notes are this course's own, built from Anthropic's guidance (sources below). It is not an Anthropic document.

#	Ask	If yes	What it costs
1	Does the job need information from outside the chat?	No: **plain chat** is enough (but the model only knows what it was trained on, up to its knowledge cutoff). One quick, current fact: **web search** (one or two searches, with citations). Many sources and a full report: **Research** (many searches that build on each other, over minutes, ending in a cited report).	Web search: seconds, counts toward usage. Research: minutes, uses your limits faster, paid plans only, needs web search on.
2	Will someone else see or reuse the result?	Ask for an **artifact**: something you'd put in front of someone. It opens beside the chat, and you can edit, reuse and share it.	On every plan, including Free. Needs code execution and file creation turned on in your settings. Starts private to you.
3	Will this work come back, with the same files and rules?	Do it in a **Project**: a workspace with its own knowledge and instructions, ready every time.	Set up once. Free plans can have up to five projects.
4	Is it a multi-step job that ends in files, spans your apps, or runs on a schedule?	**Hand it off** (Cowork). On the merged "one Claude" layout, you just ask. Cowork isn't in the exam guide, so treat it as context.	Paid plans. Multi-step tasks use more of your usage than a quick question. Claude Desktop must stay open for local files.

Answers stack. One job can be Research, inside a Project, ending in an artifact. Each feature costs minutes, usage or setup, so switch on what the job needs, and nothing more.

Your app may look different: the Chat | Cowork switch

On September 16, 2026, Anthropic began merging Claude Cowork and chat into one Claude. It reaches accounts in stages, starting with Pro and Max plans, and there's nothing to turn on. The Help Center's test: "If you're on a Pro or Max plan and your message box still shows "Chat" and "Cowork" options, you don't have it yet." This lesson was recorded on 2026-10-04 on an account that still showed the switch. On the

merged layout, there's no web search toggle (Claude searches the web when it helps), and Research opens with `/deep-research` or from the + menu. The four questions stay the same.

Key terms

- **Knowledge cutoff:** the date a model's training data ends. After it, Claude can't know what happened unless it searches. For Sonnet 5.5 it is June 2026.
- **Web search:** one or two searches for a quick, current fact, with citations.
- **Research:** many searches that build on each other, over minutes, ending in a report with citations.
- **Artifact:** something Claude makes that you'd put in front of someone. It opens beside the chat, to edit, reuse and share.
- **Project:** a workspace with its own knowledge and instructions, for work that keeps coming back.
- **Hand-off:** describing an outcome and letting Claude run a multi-step job to finished files (Cowork; on the merged layout, just ask). Not in the exam guide.

What happened in the hands-on

Claude Desktop 2.9939.4 on Linux, Chat, Sonnet 5.5 at Medium effort, one new chat, recorded on 2026-10-04. Before the first message, Memory was switched off for this one chat, and the connected apps (email, calendar, files) were switched off in the + menu, so nothing private could enter the run.

1. **Plain chat (web search unticked in the + menu).** The question: what has changed in Claude's Projects, Research and artifacts features since July 2026? Claude answered in seconds and honestly: its reliable knowledge ends in June 2026, so it wouldn't guess, and it gave no sources. It suggested turning on web search. A collapsed line read "Used a tool · Failed": Claude had tried to call a tool that doesn't exist. That was a harmless slip, and the answer itself was correct.
2. **Research (web search back on, then + → Research, blue indicator).** A three-part brief: what to find (changes to chat, Projects, Research, artifacts and Cowork since July 1, 2026, for beginners), where to look (only Anthropic's own public pages, not email, calendar or files) and what to hand back (a date and a citation for every change, under 500 words, starting right away). The run took **3 minutes 39 seconds and read 229 sources**. The video shows its start and its finish in real time, with one labelled time cut of 2 minutes 45 seconds in between. Claude returned a report with a dated table of changes. Two brief slips were visible. The source list included Wikipedia (13 sources), and the September 16 row carried a TechCrunch citation chip, even though the brief asked for Anthropic's pages only.
3. **The check.** The report's September 16 claim was compared with Anthropic's release notes: "Claude Cowork comes to every conversation", rolling out gradually to Pro and Max plans. It matched, date and all. The claim held, but a brief is a request, not a guarantee.
4. **Artifact (a normal message: Research had switched itself off after the run).** Claude made "Which feature for which job" in about 45 seconds: a six-row table (chat, web search, Research, artifacts, Projects, Cowork: the job each fits and when to pick something else) and a box, "Changed since the July 2026 exam guide", with seven dated changes, each with a source.

The exact prompts and the artifact Claude made are in this lesson's student kit.

What we checked (2026-10-04)

Claude's report and artifact are not sources. Every claim in them was checked against Anthropic's own pages.

#	Claim (as Claude wrote it)	Verdict	Official source
V1	Jul 7: Cowork came to web and mobile, with remote sessions in beta	Correct	Release notes, July 7, 2026
V2	Jul 10: memory saves individual, categorized entries instead of a daily summary	Correct	Release notes, July 10, 2026
V3	Aug 25: memory works across chat and Cowork, editable under Topics	Correct	Release notes, August 25, 2026
V4	Sep 16: chat and Cowork "merged"; no web search toggle; Research via /deep-research or "+"; manual approval is the default	**Partly wrong.** Everything is right except "merged": the change is rolling out gradually, starting with Pro and Max, and the recording account still showed the switch	Release notes, September 16, 2026; Help Center, *Claude Cowork and chat are one Claude*
V5	Sep 16: Design, Slides and Docs in any conversation; artifacts on every plan; templates in beta on paid plans	Correct	Release notes, September 16, 2026; Help Center, artifacts article
V6	Sep 17: Projects redesigned (beta, Claude Code first); existing projects unchanged	Correct	Anthropic blog, *Projects redesigned: from folder to conversation* (Sep 17, 2026); Help Center, *What are projects?*
V7	Oct 6 (scheduled): on Pro and Max, new Cowork tasks run in the cloud; the "Only on your computer" option is removed	Correct, and correctly marked as scheduled (not yet happened on 2026-10-04)	Help Center, *Get started with Claude Cowork* (heads-up)

#	Claim (as Claude wrote it)	Verdict	Official source
V8	Research "is listed for Pro and Max, not Free"	**Incomplete.** Not on Free is right, but Research is on every paid plan: Pro, Max, Team and Enterprise	Help Center, *Use research on Claude*
V9	Research sessions can use tokens quickly	Correct (the Help Center says they "can use up your limits faster")	Help Center, *Use research on Claude*
V10	Cowork: manual approval as the safe default	Correct	Help Center, *Claude Cowork and chat are one Claude*
V11	Report only, Aug 18: on Desktop, a message sent during a Research run is queued until the report is ready	Correct	Claude Desktop changelog, version dated 2026-08-18
V12	Report only, Aug 19: Cowork artifacts from this date work like normal artifacts; older live artifacts can't be edited in place	Correct	Help Center, *Use live artifacts in Claude Cowork*
V13	Report: TechCrunch citation chip; Wikipedia among the sources	The claim is correct, but the brief wasn't followed (it asked for Anthropic's pages only)	The recording
V14	Plain chat: "Used a tool · Failed"	A harmless slip: a call to a tool that doesn't exist. The answer (knowledge ends in June 2026) is correct	Help Center, *How up-to-date is Claude's training data?*

The exam link

Domain 3, Product and Model Selection, task statement 3.1 (our label; quoted word for word from the guide): "Select appropriate Claude product features (Projects, research mode, chat, artifacts)". The guide names four features and doesn't mention Cowork, so this course teaches Cowork as context. Lesson 1.1 introduced the four decisions. This lesson goes deep on the features decision, and Lessons 1.3 and 1.4 cover models and context.

The lesson's practice scenario (original, not from the exam). A project manager joins a client call in ten minutes and wants to quote a software tool's current price. What's the most appropriate way to use Claude? A: a full Research report. B: web search on, then open the cited source. C: web search off, since a price is a simple fact. D: a new Project with the tool's documents. The answer is **B**. Run question one: the job needs outside information, one current fact. C fails, because a price can change after the knowledge cutoff. A is the right tool for the wrong size of job (the Help Center's guidance: consider web search instead for a quick, specific fact when speed matters more than depth). D is setup for work that keeps coming back. B fits: a quick search, then a look at the source, because she's about to say it out loud.

Quick check

Before you move on, take this lesson's quick check. It's a few short questions and takes a couple of minutes. Module 1's quiz comes after Lesson 1.4. The exam-style question in this lesson, the quick checks, the module quizzes and the practice exams are all original, written for this course against the official blueprint. They are never copies of the real exam.

Sources (all checked 2026-10-04)

- **Anthropic, *Claude Certified Associate – Foundations Exam Guide*.** Version 1.0, effective July 2026. §6, Domain 3, task statement 3.1 (p. 5). Official download: https://everpath-course-content.s3-accelerate.amazonaws.com/instructor/6nizmqk8tpzpfjvt6qmmav7rh/public/1783542847/Claude+Certified+Associate+%E2%80%93+Foun
- **Anthropic's official CCAO-F prep course**, Course 1 of 8, *Claude Platform & Model Foundations*: "About this course" and the learning objectives.
- **Claude Academy, Claude 101:**
  - Lesson 4, *How you'll work with Claude on your desktop* (the "Claude Cowork is now just Claude" banner and the shape-of-work table): https://academy.claude.com/courses/claude-101/claude-desktop-app-chat-cowork-code
  - Lesson 5, *Introduction to projects* ("When to use Projects"): https://academy.claude.com/courses/claude-101/introduction-to-projects
  - *Creating with artifacts*: https://academy.claude.com/courses/claude-101/creating-with-artifacts
  - Lesson 10, *Research for deep dives* ("When to use Research", "Consider web search instead"): https://academy.claude.com/courses/claude-101/research-mode-for-deep-dives
- **Claude Help Center:**
  - *When should I use web search, extended thinking, and research?* (web search "with one or two tool calls"; Research "five or more tool calls over 1-3 minutes", with citations): https://support.claude.com/en/articles/11095361-when-should-i-use-web-search-extended-thinking-and-research
  - *Use research on Claude* (paid plans: Pro, Max, Team, Enterprise; needs web search on; uses limits faster): https://support.claude.com/en/articles/11088861-use-research-on-claude
  - *Enable and use web search*: https://support.claude.com/en/articles/10684626-enabling-and-using-web-search
  - *What are artifacts and how do I use them?* (the "put in front of someone" test and the criteria): https://support.claude.com/en/articles/17153992-what-are-artifacts-and-how-do-i-use-them
  - *What are projects?*: https://support.claude.com/en/articles/9517075-what-are-projects

    - *Get started with Claude Cowork*: https://support.claude.com/en/articles/13345190-get-started-with-claude-cowork
    - *Claude Cowork and chat are one Claude*: https://support.claude.com/en/articles/16761823-claude-cowork-and-chat-are-one-claude
    - *How up-to-date is Claude's training data?*: https://support.claude.com/en/articles/8114494-how-up-to-date-is-claude-s-training-data
    - *Use live artifacts in Claude Cowork*: https://support.claude.com/en/articles/14729249
    - *Release notes* (July 7, July 10, August 25 and September 16, 2026 entries): https://support.claude.com/en/articles/12138966-release-notes
- **Anthropic blog:**
    - *Claude Cowork and chat are now one Claude* (September 16, 2026): https://claude.com/blog/cowork-is-now-claude
    - *Projects redesigned: from folder to conversation* (September 17, 2026): https://claude.com/blog/projects-redesigned
- **Claude Desktop changelog** (Research message queueing, 2026-08-18): https://claude.com/docs/cowork/changelog.md
- **The app itself:** Claude Desktop 2.9939.4 on Linux, observed 2026-10-04. Menus and labels can change between versions.

What you see in the lesson is a real account. The model picker was never opened, and Settings → Account and Settings → Memory were never opened. Connected apps were switched off for the recording and switched back on afterwards.